Bob Dylan Comes Knockin' on the Pope's Door

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Bob Dylan came knockin' on the pope's door on Wednesday. The American singer-songwriter visited Pope Leo XIV, the American pope, at the Vatican during a break between concert dates in Italy. The Vatican said the meeting was brief. Leo gave Dylan a **rosary**, and Dylan gave the pope a copy of his **autobiography**, "Chronicles: Volume One." The two men had a connection before they ever met. Leo had quoted from an unpublished **protest song** Dylan wrote in 1963, "Go Away You Bomb," in his 2026 book "Disarmed and Disarming: Peace Is a Gift." In the book, Leo warned against the race to rearm and the use of **nuclear** weapons, quoting the song's words to a make-believe atomic bomb: "I hate you cause yer man-made and man-owned, an' man-handled." Dylan was accompanied by two Vatican officials, the Rev. Antonio Spadaro and Andrea Monda, the editor of the Vatican newspaper. Spadaro said Dylan had wanted to speak with Leo, and the two met in private for a few minutes. Spadaro also noted that Dylan knows the work of St. Augustine of Hippo well, and Dylan wrote "I Dreamed I Saw St. Augustine" for his 1967 album "John Wesley Harding." Dylan, who won the **Nobel Prize** for Literature in 2016, wore a black hoodie and a loose tie for the meeting, with the hood over his head in the Vatican photos. This was not his first meeting with a pope: he played for Pope John Paul II in 1997 at a concert in Bologna, Italy. Dylan, who was born Robert Zimmerman, told the Wall Street Journal in 2022 that he was a "religious person" who reads the **scriptures**, meditates and prays. At his most recent concert before the Vatican visit, he sang his 1997 song "Tryin' to Get to Heaven."

Word Treasure

autobiography -- An autobiography is a book a person writes about their own life.

rosary -- A rosary is a string of beads used in prayer.

protest song -- A protest song is a song that speaks out against something unfair.

nuclear -- Nuclear means to do with the energy inside atoms, including nuclear bombs.

scriptures -- Scriptures are holy books, like the Bible.

Nobel Prize -- The Nobel Prize is a famous award given for great work in science, literature or peace.

Background you need

The Vatican is the home of the pope, the leader of the Catholic Church, in Rome.

A pope is the head of the Catholic Church, and popes often meet famous visitors.

Bob Dylan is a famous American singer and songwriter whose songs have shaped popular music for decades.

A rosary is a string of beads used in Catholic prayer.

Break it down

LEAD: Bob Dylan meets Pope Leo XIV at the Vatican
KEY EVENT: Brief private meeting between the singer and the pope
+- WHO: Dylan, Pope Leo XIV, Spadaro and Monda
+- WHERE: The Vatican in Rome
+- WHEN: Wednesday, between concert dates in Italy
EVIDENCE: Leo quoted Dylan's 1963 song in his 2026 book about peace
OPEN QUESTION: What will Dylan play in Rome on Thursday?

Why it matters

Music and faith both bring people together, and a meeting between a famous singer and the pope shows how the two can connect.

Test what you remember

1. Who did Bob Dylan meet at the Vatican?

- (A) The Rev. Antonio Spadaro
- (B) Pope John Paul II
- (C) Pope Leo XIV
- (D) Andrea Monda

2. What did Pope Leo give Dylan?

- (A) A rosary
- (B) A book of songs
- (C) A guitar
- (D) A painting

3. What did Dylan give the pope?

- (A) A concert ticket
- (B) A black hoodie
- (C) A copy of his autobiography, Chronicles: Volume One
- (D) A copy of his newest album

4. Which Dylan song did Pope Leo quote in his 2026 book?

- (A) Go Away You Bomb
- (B) I Dreamed I Saw St. Augustine
- (C) Gotta Serve Somebody
- (D) Tryin' to Get to Heaven

5. In what year did Dylan win the Nobel Prize for Literature?

- (A) 2022
- (B) 1967
- (C) 1997
- (D) 2016

6. Where is Dylan playing on Thursday?

- (A) London
- (B) Bologna
- (C) Rome
- (D) Milan

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Pope Leo XIV: warns in his book against the race to rearm and the use of nuclear weapons

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):